

A Vietnamese nationalist and passionate communist, Ho Chi Minh devoted his life to political struggle. Many details of his career are obscure, both because he lived the clandestine existence of a revolutionary activist for many years and because his actions have been mythologized for the purposes of propaganda. Yet there is no doubt that he deserves to be recognized as the father of modern Vietnam.

Born Nguyen Sinh Cung, he was known from the age of ten as Nguyen Tat Thanh, and then as a young man as Nguyen Ai Quoc (Nguyen the Patriot). His family lived in Annam, the area of central Vietnam where the Vietnamese emperor still exercised nominal authority under French protection. Like most members of Vietnam's traditional Confucian scholar-mandarin elite, his father deeply resented foreign domination.

Ho attended the Quoc Hoc lycée in Hue, which was designed to educate select Vietnamese children in French culture and civilization. Instead of joining the colonial administration as expected, at around the age of 21, Ho set off to see the world. Working his passage on ships as a kitchen hand and taking on casual menial jobs to support himself, he spent time in the US, Britain, and France. After World War I, he became politically active, joining a group of Vietnamese nationalists in Paris as they unsuccessfully petitioned the statesmen at the Versailles peace conference to apply their principles of self-determination and democracy to Vietnam.